Papaji lowered his newspaper to check if we were wearing the helmets as instructed. Seeing that we had complied, he smiled and wished us goodbye as we sped out of the bungalow on the scooter. No sooner had we moved a few hundred metres away from home than we removed our helmets. Soon, we were flying down the road at a speed that could rival a cheetah's. It was thrilling. I could feel the wind in my hair, and it made me happy, so much so that I forgot to slow down as we entered the main road. Just as I steered left, a cyclist appeared out of nowhere in front of me, and I panicked. It was too late to apply the brakes and I collided with the cyclist head-on. The next thing I remember was lying flat on the road with pedestrians gathered around me, helping me up. I felt a sharp pain on my right cheekbone as I tried to get up. Navneet was lying next to me, trying to get up too. Another group of men pulled the half-conscious cyclist from under my scooter. He was seemingly unhurt. Blood was dripping down my chin. Luckily, Navneet had got only a few minor bruises. I looked at my reflection in the rear-view mirror of my fallen scooter. My right cheek had turned a dark red.

I knew I was in for some serious trouble. Papaji would know I wasn't wearing a helmet if he saw me. The bleeding stopped but I feared going back home. So I dropped Navneet off at her house and headed back, praying for some miracle to avoid confronting Papaji. As I edged closer to my home, I thought of sneaking in by quietly pulling the scooter inside. I peered over the boundary wall to see if Papaji was still in the lawn. There was nobody, save a chair and a small peg table. So I quickly went inside and parked the scooter in the stand.

'How bad is it?' It was Papaji's voice from behind me. I stopped dead in my tracks.

'What, Papaji?' I was terrified.

'I can see the dents on the scooter,' he said plainly.

'Oh . . . it's just a small dent. I'll get it fixed.' I trembled as I spoke.

'It's not about the scooter, Gunju,' he said. 'How bad is your injury?'

I did not say anything.

'Turn around,' he said calmly.